

"The state police cannot handle this. CBI should be asked to investigate."

PRASAD RANJAN RAY, STATE HOME SECRETARY



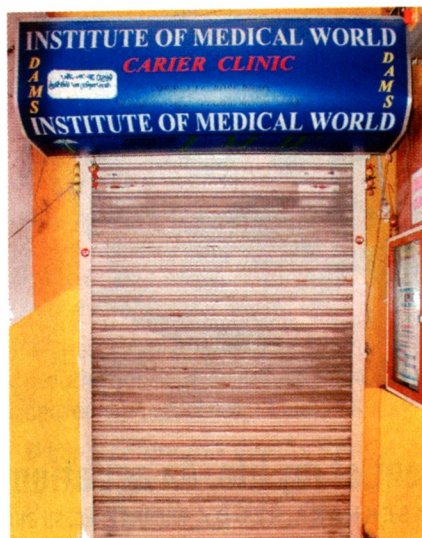
persuade him/her to cough up some lakhs, even promising that he/she wouldn't be required to sit for the examination. In Durgapur, Smita Chatterjee and her associate Tarakeshwar Singh, who own a fake coaching centre, have been arrested. Last week, the police also arrested a mechanical engineer, Syed Abrar from Bangalore, who ran a coaching centre called Ascent Institute of IT in the city's Annapurna Complex. Abrar's phone records show that he was in regular touch with Jha, Pathak and senior members of various private colleges in Bangalore. In addition to Chatterjee's Durgapur centre, the police have located at least four more fake centres.

The investigating team so far has nailed six people who had paid up to Rs 6 lakh in exchange for a seat. Kumar Singha Roy, who got through the North Bengal Medical College (but didn't take admission) and his father Brindaban were one of the firsts to be arrested. They have confessed paying Rs 5,83,000. Among the other aspirants who have been arrested so far are Abhishek Saha (who got through Calcutta Medical College), Sourabh Das, Rupa Majumdar (scored 707th rank in the examination) and her

mother Ruby Majumdar, who were arrested from Varanasi.

The arrest of the Majumdars opened new doors in the investigations—involvement of dummy candidates. Acting upon a huge risk and presuming that the examiners would not take a close look and tally the photographs on the admit-cards, the gang tapped a huge network of medical students who vaguely

WRITE AND WRONG: Protesting students and parents (above); a fake coaching centre in Kolkata



resembled the aspirants. The photographs were distorted, with software like Photoshop, by slightly altering features, changing hair-styles and making them unclear. Each dummy candidate was paid something between Rs 40,000 to over Rs 1 lakh for the job. So far, the police have been able to arrest only one dummy candidate, in addition to Syed Abrar, Babli Kazmi (who doesn't even have a BA degree but makes a living out of these tests) from Varanasi. She is believed to have impersonated Rupa Majumdar this year.

"It is proving extremely difficult to nail the dummies," says Kumar. The resources of the police are limited con-

sidering the magnitude of the crime. It is suspected that six dummy candidates had taken the medical entrance tests in Kolkata this year. The state police's Detective Department is now tallying the handwritings of the 1,105 selected candidates with their post-qualification counselling papers to detect the dummies.

The racket is believed to be linked with some of the top colleges in Kolkata, Bangalore and also Pune and Delhi. They keep track of vacant seats in colleges and strike deals with college authorities to get their students admitted through what is known as the "management quota". And this is not illegal as the management decides what is to be done with the remaining seats.

The racket is getting murkier with each passing day. State home secretary Prasad Ranjan Ray has said the case should be handed over to CBI, as it is getting too big for the state police to handle. "No one from the Health Department is involved in the scam," says Mishra. It remains to be seen how much truth his words carry for what has been discovered so far merely seems to be the tip of the iceberg.